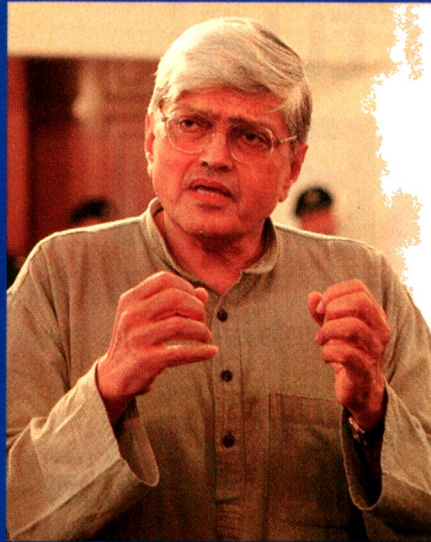


MACHINE MALFUNCTION AND GOVERNOR GANDHI UNITE BENGAL HOUSE

KOLKATA | Singsation

Governor Gopal Krishna Gandhi found a way to get the entire West Bengal political class to sing to his tune—or sing in one voice. On March 9, the music system inside the Assembly which plays the national anthem during inauguration of sessions, ran into starting trouble. Staff members were throwing switches in minor panic and electricians were being summoned. Gandhi, already at the podium for his opening speech, waited for a few seconds and then said, “Let us sing the national anthem ourselves.” The response was immediate—a rare sight of unity in a House. Now Bengal waits for its masters to implement policies with such unanimity.

by Elora Sen



GOPAL KRISHNA GANDHI

60

out of 200 small towns in Karnataka have reasonable underground drainage.

BANGALORE | Underground Row

This has the makings of a big stink. The Karnataka State Pollution Control Board has filed cases against key officials of urban local bodies (ULB) for failing to provide proper drainage facilities and treatment plants. Only 60 of the 200 ULBs, civic bodies that run Karnataka's small towns, have proper underground drainage facilities. The Board is unhappy with the rate of compliance with their norms—a measly 30 per cent. The state Government says that 100 per cent compliance can happen but in its own good time and at a cost of Rs 10,000 crore. by Stephen David

PATNA | The Oscar Effect



NITISH KUMAR ON A RICKSHAW

The Congress may have bought the copyright to ‘Jai Ho’, but that hasn’t stopped politicians on the other side of the political divide from drawing *Slumdog Millionaire* mileage. Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar rode a rickshaw to a Patna movie hall recently to watch the Oscar-feted movie and then visited the Janata Dal (United) office. With security personnel following him on bicycle or on foot, Nitish obviously believed he had succeeded in connecting with the common man by using the common man’s transport to watch a movie depicting a common man’s life. That assumption is still open to debate but the rickshaw ride did certainly win eyeballs and bypass the Election Commission’s code of conduct.

by Amitabh Srivastava

BANGALORE | Party Trouble

The Bangalore police certainly didn’t look up the word ‘rave’ in the dictionary before they zeroed in on a private party at a farmhouse in Ramanagara on the outskirts of the city recently. Following complaints of noisy revelling from neighbours, what should’ve been a simple “party’s over, go home” warning translated into the arrests of 101 people, 38 of them foreigners. Despite the police’s attempt-



The arrested partygoers

pts to term it a rave, no drugs or narcotics were found at the venue. The partygoers were then rounded up under Section 36 of the Karnataka Excise Act which deals with illegal sale of liquor, and had to spend the next day in jail until they were released on bail. Incidentally the owner of the farmhouse, Ramkrishnaiah, who was private secretary to Congress leader Siddaramaiah when the latter was deputy chief minister, was not booked. Looks like the police got confused by the difference between policing and moral policing. by Swagata Sen